

Linux is efficient and easy to use but it does not dominate the PC industry. People usually opt for laptops bundled with the Windows operating system because its usage is pretty straightforward. (Whether the operating system is the best choice or not is a different question.) Linux requires the user to make many choices like the flavour of Linux to install—Fedora or Ubuntu or any of the other numerous flavours available. You also need to decide whether you want a GNOME or KDE system. This might prove daunting to a non-technical person.

So, what do I mean by ‘open source wars?’ Well, I use the term to denote the competition between different open source software for dominance. To be frank, to neutral observers, these debates and the competition often look unnecessary.

The important question is: Are these debates over the adoption of some particular software as intense as I portray them to be? Well, the term ‘UNIX wars’ was coined in the 1980s to denote the feud between different UNIX standards to become the dominant one. This shows that the mutual animosity between the fans of certain related yet competing software is far more serious and profound than expected.

Fortunately, for all of us, these wars are almost always fought on the internet. In this article, we will discuss some of the key battles fought in the open source world regarding the adoption of particular software. But jokes apart, this article will also tell us how even the silliest disputes among the members of a development team can lead to conflicts and derail the pace of software development and technology adoption.

UNIX wars

This is the oldest of all the wars in the open source world. The initial hostility was between AT&T UNIX

and BSD UNIX. Though UNIX was developed by AT&T (or should I say Ken Thompson and Dennis Ritchie) in the late 1960s, University of California, Berkeley contributed a lot too, and this led to the creation of BSD (Berkeley Software Distribution) UNIX.

Due to technical as well as commercial reasons, AT&T UNIX and BSD UNIX parted ways in the early 1980s. This marked the beginning of intense competition between these two factions to become the *de facto* standard of UNIX. This competition, known as the UNIX war, continued well into the 1990s.



Fig. 1: FreeBSD logo

But today this war is over with a clear winner (even though it was a late entrant)—Linux. Linux is a UNIX-like operating system and, as of today, the most dominant open source operating system.

It is good to know that licensing issues and UNIX wars were one of the reasons behind the creation of Linux. But, before we move on, what happened to BSD UNIX and AT&T UNIX? Well, they are not extinct.

If you want to have a feel of BSD UNIX, try FreeBSD—an open source implementation of BSD UNIX. I consider FreeBSD as a runner-up in the UNIX wars, as it is open source and the most popular among different BSD UNIX derivatives. Fig. 1 displays the logo of FreeBSD.

If you want to have a feel of AT&T UNIX, you could use Oracle Solaris, HP-UX, or IBM AIX. But remember, these are all proprietary operating systems. Thus, the first open source war ended with a number of proprietary operating systems and Linux emerging as the winner.

The distro wars

Now that Linux has emerged as the clear winner, let us discuss the distro wars. Earlier I believed that the number of Linux distros was in the hundreds, but now I suspect that it might be in the thousands.

Though so many Linux distributions are competing for dominance, most of them are either Debian based or Red Hat based. This reduces our choices by a large margin. The other major independent distributions of Linux are Arch Linux, Gentoo Linux, openSUSE, and Slackware.

Not unlike the UNIX wars, this is also an ongoing war with no clear winner. It is safe to predict that the competition for the most popular Linux distro will continue for a long



Fig. 2: Debian logo

time. But who is leading the competition as of now?

A website called DistroWatch ranks Linux distributions based on their popularity. It ranks these distributions based on the number of times a distribution-specific page in DistroWatch itself is accessed. Thus, the website acts more or less like a poll aggregator. Moreover, DistroWatch claims that the ranking is ‘a light-hearted way of measuring the popularity of Linux distributions.’

So, you should not try to assess the actual market share of Linux distributions with this ranking. According to DistroWatch, the ten major Linux distributions are Linux Mint, Ubuntu, MX Linux, Arch Linux, Gentoo Linux, Slackware, Debian, Fedora, openSUSE, and CentOS.

As mentioned earlier, Arch Linux, Gentoo Linux, openSUSE, and Slackware are independent of Debian and Red Hat. Among the remaining distri-